

DELHI | Nuclear Freeze

CPI(M) GENERAL SECRETARY PRAKASH KARAT (CENTRE) AT A PRESS MEET

Liability for Nuclear Damage Bill. The bill seeks to cap the liability of nuclear plant operators at Rs 500 crore in the event of an accident involving nuclear plants. It was introduced to limit the liability of US companies which have emphasised that they will not enter a deal with India unless the bill is passed. Not surprisingly, the bill has hit a wall of resistance and split the UPA nuclear family like an atom.

The deal is Prime Minister Mahmoan Singh's pet project and the passing of the bill is central to its progress. In this regard, the Government needs to strike new deals with the Opposition and even some of its own allies.

by Shafi Rahman

GUJARAT | Legal Leeway

Days after the Supreme Court-appointed Special Investigation Team (SIT) summoned Narendra Modi for questioning regarding the Gulbarga Society massacre, the Gujarat chief minister has got a reprieve. The summons were issued on the basis of the court petition of Zakia, the wife of Congress leader Ehsan Jafri who was among the 69 killed in the Gulbarga



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Society carnage. Eminent lawyer Ram Jethmalani made a plea on behalf of one of the accused. It led the Supreme Court agreeing to first hear an old plea from those named in Zakia's petition that the apex court should have heard them before asking the SIT to look into her complaint. In April 2009, the court had asked the SIT to take up Zakia's complaint without giving some of the accused a hearing. Zakia accuses 63 people, including Modi and several police and IAS officers, of being responsible for the riots.

by Uday Mahurkar

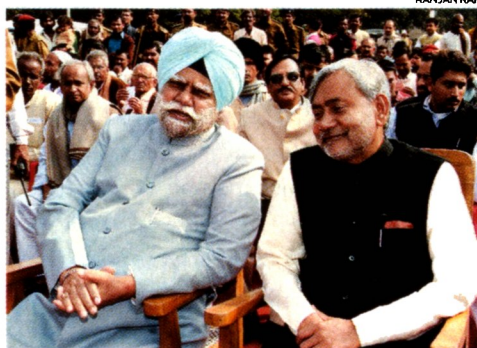
After risking its existence to push the Indo-US Nuclear Bill through Parliament in its last term, the UPA Government has blinked this time around. With the Left and Right joining hands again, the Government has put on hold plans to introduce the Civil



During the passage of the Women's Reservation Bill in the Rajya Sabha, Sonia Gandhi told the agitating Yadavs with a rare mischievous smile, "Don't worry, the prime minister will bring in a bill for male reservation."

PATNA | Rental Value

It's payback with a touch of irony. Nitish Kumar's Government has ordered the payment of Rs 3.13 lakh from the Bihar Contingency Fund to pay the penal rent slapped on former governor Buta Singh for illegally occupying a bungalow in Lutyen's Delhi from March 2004 to November 2005. That happens to be the period when Singh also occupied the Raj Bhavan in Patna as governor without surrendering his official bungalow in Delhi, allotted to him as an MP in the 13th Lok Sabha. The payment has been "regularised" by making a provision of Rs 3.13 lakh in the recently passed third supplementary budget of 2009-10. The irony? Singh had recommended dissolution of the Assembly in



RANJAN RAHI

SINGH (LEFT) AND NITISH

May 2005 just when Nitish was about to cobble together a majority. Nitish's magnanimity is understandable now, for had Singh not done so, Nitish's hold on power would have been shaky and not strong like it's now. The sad part is that the taxpayers' money is now being used to bail Singh out.

by Amitabh Srivastava